

Private folders — `_folder`

Live demo: `/private-folders` · Code: `src/app/private-folders/`

What it is

Prefixing a folder name with an **underscore** (`_components` , `_lib`) makes it a **private folder**: it (and everything inside it) is **opted out of routing**. It can never become a URL — it's only ever reached by being imported.

Files in this folder

Path	Routable?
<code>private-folders/page.tsx</code>	→ <code>/private-folders</code>
<code>private-folders/_components/Banner.tsx</code>	imported only
<code>private-folders/_lib/data.ts</code>	imported only

Try opening `/private-folders/_components` in the browser → **404**.

Private folder vs colocation

Colocation already prevents non-`page` / `route` files from being routable, so private folders aren't *required*. They add value by:

- Separating UI/logic from routing clearly.
- Consistent, recognizable structure across a codebase.
- Avoiding name clashes with future Next.js special files.

Tips

- The whole subtree is excluded, not just the top folder.
- Need a literal underscore **in a URL**? Use the encoded form `%5Ffolder`.

Interview Q&A

- **Q: What does a leading underscore on a folder do?**Opts the folder and all its subfolders out of the router — they can't be URLs.
- **Q: If colocation already prevents routing, why use private folders?**For intent, consistent organization, and to avoid clashing with Next.js reserved filenames.